MCP

Title:

Take Care of It

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CHARACTERS

Alex

Jerry

Scammer 1

Scammer 2

Mercenary 1

Mercenary 2

Mercenary 3

Narrator

AUTHOR'S NOTE: The characters are written so as to be played by any gender.

AUTHOR'S NOTE: Mercenary 2 and 3 can be combined if desired.

SUMMARY: What happens when your wonderful night of sleep is shattered by a text message sent by two dimwitted scammers? Well, if you are a trillionaire, you hire a band of ex-soldier mercenaries to "take care of it". Whatever "take care of it" means.

(Twilight Zone - esque beginning. Alex is sleeping peacefully during the narrator's introduction.)

NARRATOR

It was a night just like any other night. A cool 71 degrees compared to earlier in the day which saw a high of 93.5. Alex had gone to bed early. 8:47 pm to be precise. And at 2:43 am. Alex got a text. (ding)

(Alex jerks awake.)

ALEX

This must be an emergency!

NARRATOR

A natural thought. For a text at 2:43 am must be an emergency.

ALEX

Did the stock market plummet? Did my dad finally decide to talk to me? Does someone want to know if "I'm up"?

NARRATOR

But it was none of these things.

ALEX

(Reading Text)

You have been preapproved for a loan, click here to accept.

NARRATOR

(The narrator is responding, or trying to respond to, Alex's reaction.)

The anger started low. Lower. Maybe a little lower. There you go. And then slowly boiled up. Slowly. Okay, fine, quickly boiled up.

ALEX and NARRATOR

SPAM TEXT.

NARRATOR

There was only one thing to do.

ALEX

I need to take care of it.

(Transition music)

SCAMMER 1

That was awesome. 2:43 in the morning loan approval text.

SCAMMER 2

The perfect time to send a text.

SCAMMER 1

No doubt.

SCAMMER 2

They are going to click it and totally give us their credit card information.

SCAMMER 1

And then we can buy stuff.

SCAMMER 2

We are finally going to get HBO Max without commercials.

SCAMMERS

Excellent, Excellent

(They high five)

(Transition)

ALEX

Listen Jerry, I need you to put together a team to take care of this. Can you track these scammers down?

JERRY

Alex, you are a trillionaire, yes, yes I can do that.

ALEX

Excellent.

(Transition)

SCAMMERS

Excellent, excellent.

SCAMMER 1

What do you think would happen if someone had access to like, a trillion dollars, and used all of those resources to hunt us down because of a spam text we sent?

SCAMMER 2

Whoah. Great question. I never thought about that. Whoah. I mean, how much?

SCAMMER 1

A trillion dollars.

SCAMMER 2

Nothing, I mean nothing we could do, a trillion dollars? No way.

SCAMMER 1

So we are screwed?

SCAMMER 2

Don't worry. This isn't a movie. No one is going to use their vast wealth to track down two lowly scammers.

SCAMMER 1

Oh, good point, you are right.

SCAMMER 2

All they need to do is respond with "Stop" and we have to stop. It's like, the rules.

SCAMMER 1

What if they had access to an elite paramilitary group full of people led by a quiet loner who suffered a personal tragedy which somehow made them even more powerful by accessing the power of staring out the window while it rained?

SCAMMER 2

We are totally safe, there is no way that the exact set of circumstances needed to imperil our safety would ever actually happen.

SCAMMER 1

Because this isn't a movie.

SCAMMER 2

Exactly. And there is no rain in the forecast.

SCAMMERS

Excellent, Excellent.

(TRANSITION)

ALEX

I want this to happen now, Jerry. Remember I have

(Dramatic Pause, mug to audience)

1.68 trillion dollars.

JERRY

(Makes beeping noises on handheld device).

Found them.

ALEX

That was surprisingly quick.

JERRY

If we are living in a world in which you have 1.68 trillion dollars, then it is that quick.

ALEX

My apologies. I didn't realize that my having 1.68 trillion dollars would impact reality.

JERRY

Yes, I would say that having a gross amount of money creates a different reality for you than most.

ALEX

So wait, you are saying that when one person has a lot of money, it impacts how they see and experience the world?

(long pause. As in several seconds. Make it uncomfortable.)

JERRY: Yes.

(Transition)

SCAMMER 1

What are you doing?

SCAMMER 2

Checking out what movies are on HBO Max.

SCAMMER 1

I'm finally going to watch Game of Thrones.

(Transition)

JERRY

You have your orders, Captain.

MERCENARY 1

Um, I'm not a captain.

JERRY

You have your orders rogue mercenary ex-soldier who suffered a personal tragedy and were convinced to take on a mission even though you retired that only you can lead, despite the fact that you haven't kept up with training or physical fitness the past six months and have made questionable life choices that would cause one to question your ability to make sound decisions.

MERCENARY 1

You didn't mention the gambling or drinking.

JERRY

I was just lumping that under "questionable life choices".

MERCENARY 1

Fair enough. What are we getting paid again?

JERRY

250 grand each.

MERCENARY 1

That seems excessive.

JERRY

Agreed. But this is the world of the trillionaire.

ALEX

Aha! My crackpot team of mercenaries!

MERCENARY 2

Who you calling a crackpot?

MERCENARY 1

Perhaps a crack team of mercenaries?

ALEX

Crack?! They are drug addicts, Jerry?

JERRY

No!

MERCENARY 1

We just drink. And gamble. And make other questionable life choices.

MERCENARY 3

Like invest in dogecoin.

ALEX

There are only three of you?.

MERCENARY 1

There are six total, but we didn't think you would have time to meet us all, and we thought it might be confusing keeping us all straight, so just the three of us here.

ALEX

So, you are crackpots.

MERCENARY 1

A crack team. Crack as in "excellent or first rate" is slang from the 1790's. A crack team of mercenaries.

MERCENARY 2

Crackpot is derived from "pot" being slang for "head" and "crack" meaning there is a split in it, or it is not whole.

MERCENARY 3

And that dates back to the 1630's.

JERRY

Is etymology part of your training?

MERCENARY 2

Watch who you are calling an etymologist.

MERCENARY 1

It's important to understand where worlds come from.

MERCENARY 3:

And how they are used.

JERRY

Are you insinuating that words have power…

ALEX

And the history of words hold clues to connotative meaning apart from the denotation or current use in the vernacular?

MERCENARY 1

And shared and understood meaning of words and phrases is important for clear communication.

ALEX

Could you be a crack team of mercenary crackpots?

(Long Pause as the mercenaries think. Look at each other. Triple take. Think. Weigh it.)

MERCENARY 1

That works.

JERRY

You have your coordinates.

ALEX

And you will be taking care of it.

MERCENARY 1

Take care of it?

JERRY and ALEX

Take care of it.

MERCENARY 2

So, by take care of it, you mean….

ALEX

Exactly.

MERCENARY 3

So?

ALEX

Exactly.

MERCENARY 1

Take care of it?

ALEX

Take care of it.

(Transition)

SCAMMERS

Excellent, Excellent.

SCAMMER 1

We should send another text, because we haven't gotten any bites yet.

(ALARM SOUNDS)

SCAMMER 2

What is that?

SCAMMER 1

Someone has broken our perimeter!

SCAMMER 2

I told you setting up an elaborate surveillance system to warn us of intruders was a good idea!

SCAMMER 1

This is not the time for "I told you so!"

SCAMMER 2

What do we do?

MERCENARY 1

(Static noise of walkie talkie)

Pincer move alpha bravo echo charlie.

MERCENARY 2

(Static noise of walkie talkie)

Charlie Foxtrot egress ingress.

MERCENARY 3

(Static noise of walkie talkie)

Alpha. Romero.

MERCENARY 2

(Static noise of walkie talkie)

Toyota. Corolla.

MERCENARY 1

In position.

MERCENARY 3

What are the ROE's?

MERCENARY 1

ROE? Of course you are referring to Rules of Engagement, for anyone on the team who is listening who doesn't know what ROE is and would need to know what it is in order to understand this bit.

MERCENARY 2

We all know what ROE means. We are all former soldiers who have suffered personal tragedies, retired, but then took one last mission that only we could succeed in doing.

MERCENARY 1

Just in case someone didn't know what it meant. Or forgot. That it is the expectations of how we could conduct ourselves and the amount of force we would use in the field. (Pause) In case someone forgot. (Pause) What it meant.

MERCENARY 2

Cool.

MERCENARY 1

The ROE's are pretty cool. We are being paid a gross amount of money to take care of the problem.

MERCENARY 3

What does "take care of it" mean?

MERCENARY 1

You know. Take care of it.

MERCENARY 2

But like….

MERCENARY 3

Take care of it?

MERCENARY 1

Exactly.

MERCENARY 2

But exactly what.

MERCENARY 1

No time! ATTACK!!!

(Mercenaries scream, transition to the SCAMMERs screaming.)

SCAMMER 1 and 2

I don't want to die!

MERCENARY 2

Prepare to be taken care of!

MERCENARY 3

Whatever that is!

SCAMMER 1

I'm too young to die!

SCAMMER 2

I'll never get HBO Max!

SCAMMER 1

Why? Why are you doing this?

MERCENARY 1

Our employer was woken up at 2:43 in the morning by a spam text message.

SCAMMER 1

That wasn't us!

SCAMMER 2

No, that was us.

(Scammer 1 gives a look.)

That totally wasn't us.

MERCENARY 1

Our employer has 1.68 trillion dollars. We know it was you.

MERCENARY 2

And you are toast!

SCAMMER 1

What are you going to do to us?

SCAMMER 2

Are you going to make us cancel our ad-free Hulu subscription and force us to watch ads whenever we watch Hulu????

MERCENARY 1

That seems…

SCAMMER 2

Take my eyes instead.

SCAMMER 1

Wait, if you are doing an eye for an eye, wouldn't you just wake us up when we were sleeping? Thus robbing us of a good night's sleep?

SCAMMER 2

Stop giving them ideas!

MERCENARY 1

We are to take care of it.

MERCENARY 2

Whatever that means!

MERCENARY 3

Are we killing them?

SCAMMER 1

KILLING?!

SCAMMER 2

Am I choosing between that and Hulu with ads?

SCAMMER 1

You can't ever get the sleep back. So, nothing you do will ever get the sleep lost back. Erefore, you can never have revenge. Erefore, you can never fulfill your mission. Erefore….

SCAMMER 2

You need to go back to your employer and say you were given a Sisyphean task.

MERCENARY 2

That's the dude who rolled the boulder up the hill in hell and it kept rolling back down, right?

SCAMMER 2

What?

SCAMMER 1

Look. What do you want?

MERCENARY 1

To make sure our employer is never bothered by your spam messages again.

SCAMMER 1

What's the number?

MERCENARY 1

555-555-555 (pause) 3

SCAMMER 1

(types in)

Got it. Off the list.

MERCENARY 2

That's it?

SCAMMER 2

You could have also replied to the original message with STOP. Then we would take it off as well.

MERCENARY

That works?

SCAMMER 1

For us at least. Yeah.

MERCENARY 2

Let's mess them up to leave a message for the other spammers.

SCAMMERS 1 and 2

Whoah whoah whoah whoah whoah whoah whoah whoah (pause) whoah

SCAMMER 2

That is an extreme reaction.

MERCENARY 3

Is it?

MERCENARY 1

They have a point. Our employer is off the list.

SCAMMER 1

Yup.

MERCENARY 1

Let's get out of here. It's been taken care of.

MERCENARY 2

Whatever that means.

(TRANSITION)

MERCENARY 1

You will never get a text message from them again.

ALEX

You took care of it?

MERCENARY 1

We did.

ALEX

Excellent. Now I can finally sleep. Knowing it's been taken care of. That is all I want. A good night's sleep.

(Alex falls asleep. Narrator enters to bookend the beginning.)

NARRATOR

And so Alex slept the sleep of one who was content in the knowledge that it had been taken care of. But reality can be harsh. Or, in this case, real dumb.

(Transition)

SCAMMER 1

That was a close call. This was a good idea to take a break for a night to clear our heads.

SCAMMER 2

Yeah, right? I think riding dirt bikes that are not street legal and have no mufflers through a random neighborhood at 2:43 in the morning is real relaxing.

SCAMMER 1

Wait. Do you think we should wait until daytime?

SCAMMER 2

No way. We don't want to bother people and get in their way. Didn't we learn our lesson?

SCAMMER 1

Good call. At night everyone is inside and out of our way. All asleep.

SCAMMER 2

Right. A perfect time to ride our super loud dirt bikes with no mufflers - which neighborhood should we choose?

(Transition)

(Alex sleeping, narrator standing over)

NARRATOR

Vroom vroom.

(Alex wakes up.)

END